Oracy for learning

Teaching speaking and listening explicitly

Use oracy routines to teach speaking and listening as skills that support disciplinary thinking. Clarify whether students are exploring an idea or presenting a developed explanation.

How to do it well

1 Build stable routines. Use predictable partners and explicit listening norms so transitions are quick and expectations are equitable.

2 Protect thinking before talking. Give pupils silent time to retrieve, annotate, select evidence or draft a first sentence.

3 Structure the cognitive question. Specify what pupils must explain, compare, justify or improve—not merely that they should discuss.

4 Provide the language or stimulus. Use a concrete example, text, image, sentence stem or target vocabulary when it helps pupils express the same ambitious idea.

5 Create listening accountability. Ask partners to restate, challenge or build, then cold call pupils to share their own or their partner's thinking.

What this sounds like

"This is exploratory talk. Offer an idea, ask a question and revise your explanation if the evidence changes your view. Afterwards, write the conclusion you can justify."

Classroom example. In Social Sciences, pupils use exploratory talk to test an explanation, ask for evidence and revise a tentative claim. A later presentational response requires a coherent conclusion using disciplinary vocabulary. The teacher models the listening and questioning moves, so talk quality is taught rather than assumed from the presence of discussion.

Top tips that make the technique work

Teach the language. Sentence stems and key vocabulary can help students articulate a complex relationship without supplying the content.

Make listening active. Partners can restate, build, question or challenge using evidence.

Distinguish exploratory from presentational talk. Tentative ideas and a polished explanation have different purposes.

Rehearse a specific talk move. Practise giving evidence or disagreeing respectfully before expecting an extended discussion.

Follow with writing where useful. A short revised explanation can consolidate what the talk clarified.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Teach both speaking and listening explicitly.	Assuming fluent speakers already reason well.
Connect talk to the subject learning.	Unstructured conversation without a cognitive purpose.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

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